

after the traffickers and money-launderers behind the insurgency, the Bush administration pushed for a broad scale aerial spraying of poppy fields". Unfortunately this played "into the hands of traffickers and terrorists", as it drastically increased the prices of opium and increased profits for the drug dealers and the Taliban.

Indian readers will have a special interest in particularly one section of the book. It was in a Dubai café, "drinking cappuccinos" with one Riaz that Peters learnt, "how the boss of South Asia's underworld launders millions of dollars in Afghan drug money". This "undisputed crime lord" is Dawood Ibrahim, and Riaz laundered money for him for over a decade. Dawood, wanted in India for the 1993 Mumbai blasts and accused in narcotics smuggling, has the dubious distinction of being the only person Washington has designated both a "global Terrorist Supporter" and a "Foreign Narcotics kingpin". After the 1993 blasts, he took refuge in Karachi "reportedly under the protection of the ISI". It was then that the D-company began working in the region's opium trade. Dawood travelled to Afghanistan "under the protection of the Taliban" and brokered a "financial arrangement to share

"If you want to understand what Osama bin Laden is up to, you have to understand what Dawood Ibrahim is up to."

smuggling routes with bin Laden". A former senior CIA official told Peters, "If you want to understand what Osama bin Laden is up to, you have to understand what Dawood Ibrahim is up to."

According to Riaz, all that the D-company does now is "launder drug money" through front companies established in the UAE. For less than \$20,000, Riaz could set up a totally fabricated company which would move millions of dollars into the UAE every year. These earnings would then be pumped into the stock market, where they come out clean. Another place to launder money was probably the Karachi Stock Exchange (KSE). For instance, in 2006, "\$120 billion was pumped through the KSE, a year when the country's economy totalled only about \$130 billion" and Dawood is believed to be "spending most of his time behind the high walls of a Karachi mansion", probably monitoring the KSE.

As Peters concludes, "Eight years after 9/11, the greatest single failure in the war on terror" is not that bin Laden is at large or that the Taliban may come back to power or "that the al Qaeda is regrouping in Pakistan's tribal areas and probably planning fresh attacks on the West, it is the spectacular incapacity of Western law enforcement to disrupt the flow that is keeping their networks afloat". Remember it cost al Qaeda only \$500, 000 to finance 9/11. These days, terrorist groups, as Peters reveals in her extraordinary book, earn that from dope in about a week. ■

BollyWow

This is one American's magnificent obsession with India's dream factory

By Kaveree Bamzai



BOLLYWOOD BECOMES HER
by MEREDITH
MCGUIRE
Tranquebar
Price: Rs 295
Pages: 314

Ok. How do you check the desi quotient of the Indian you're dating? Quick, ask him to sing a complete song from *Kuch Kuch Hota Hai* (KKHH). If that doesn't work, ask him to name the actor who played Kajol's fiancé in *Dilwale Dulhania Le Jayenge* (DDLJ). Gotcha. If he can't answer that, he's not worthy of a desi-loving *gori*, even if he's an NRI named Raj and knots his pastel coloured sweater around his shoulders. Part paean to DDLJ and its "symbiotic evolution", KKHH, and part ode to Shah Rukh Khan, *Bollywood Becomes Her* is the story of one woman's magnificent obsession with India. Less philosophical than *Eat, Pray, Love*'s Indian interlude and not as funny as Jessica Hines' discovery of Bollywood through Amitabh Bachchan, it does nevertheless have its aha moments. Among them: wasn't Gandhi the guy who wore the little glasses and the diaper? How do heroines change their outfits twice in five seconds? And why is Bhagyashree gazing imploringly at Salman Khan's groin on the cover of *Maine Pyar Kiya*'s DVD?

There's no mystery in this romance. You know McGuire's *gori* heroine, who wears salwar kameez to Berkeley and polyester saris to weddings, is fated to be with the desi guy called Dev who shares her passion for Jackie Shroff. You also know her love for Bollywood involving marathon DVD sessions will not go unrequited, leading to a lifetime of fulfilling film scholarship. And role-playing. Sometimes she's virtuous meets spunky with a dash of wit, like Aditi in *Jaane Tu... Ya Jaane Na* and Geet in *Jab We Met*. At other times, she's the blushing bride, touching the feet of her would-be in-laws. But at all times, she's a faithful Indophile, who doesn't mistake lassi for a drink named after a dog, thinks Madonna bastardised Sanskrit in her henna video, is named Meg but calls herself Meghna, and feels insulted when someone compares Lata Mangeshkar's singing to Alvin and the Chipmunks. ■